

Standards and WCAG

What you need to know

- 1. A shared benchmark.** The Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) are W3C's testable requirements for accessible web content. [1]
- 2. Four principles organize the standard.** Perceivable: sense information. Operable: use controls. Understandable: follow meaning and behavior. Robust: work with assistive technology. [1]
- 3. Requirements differ from advice.** Success criteria determine conformance. Understanding documents explain them; techniques offer ways to meet them, not mandatory recipes. [1]
- 4. Levels build on one another.** A requires all A criteria; AA adds all AA criteria; AAA adds all AAA criteria. A criterion with no applicable content is satisfied. Conformance is not an average score. [2]
- 5. Evaluate the whole experience.** Whole pages and complete processes must conform to the rules. There must be no content that blocks access.
- 6. Evidence has limits.** Automated scans need human evaluation. Test with users to find unmet needs. Technical conformance alone establishes neither universal usability nor every legal obligation. [1-3]

How to think about it

Which version, level, and pages are in scope? Which criteria apply? Can users complete every step? Combine automated tool results with your judgment.

Example · judge the complete process

A registration form passes a scan, but the next step traps keyboard focus. **The process cannot claim AA:** every step must conform. [2, 3]

Common mistake

“AA means everyone can use it.” Users may still have needs beyond the criteria. Conformance and usability are related, but distinct. [1, 2]

Authoritative sources · W3C

[\[1\] WCAG structure](#) / [\[2\] Conformance](#) / [\[3\] Evaluation](#)

Text, Scale, and Reflow

What you need to know

- 1. Enlargement needs space.** Text resizing enlarges letters; page zoom enlarges the page and reduces available layout space. Wrapping lines and stacking columns are expected. [4, 5]
- 2. Text must enlarge to 200%.** Resize Text (1.4.4, AA) requires this without assistive technology or lost content/function. Captions and images of text are exceptions to this criterion. [4]
- 3. Reflow is a separate requirement.** At AA (1.4.10), vertically scrolling content must work at **320 CSS pixels wide** without loss or two-direction scrolling: equivalent to a 1280-pixel viewport at 400% zoom. Horizontally scrolling content uses a 256-CSS-pixel height. [5]
- 4. Exceptions are local.** Maps and tables may need two dimensions for meaning or use. That does not excuse sideways scrolling in surrounding instructions or controls. [5]
- 5. Spacing overrides must work.** At AA (1.4.12), supported text must tolerate line height of 1.5× font size, paragraph spacing of 2×, letter spacing of 0.12×, and word spacing of 0.16× without loss. These are test settings, not required defaults. [6]
- 6. Function matters the most.** These criteria do not set one minimum font size. Preferred heading sizes are design choices. Clipped instructions and unreachable buttons are barriers to usage, and should be avoided. [4-6]

How to think about it

Test 200% enlargement, narrow-width reflow, and spacing overrides. Can you read everything and finish a task? Is any two-dimensional layout essential?

Example · judge the exception

At 400% zoom, a timetable scrolls sideways within its area while instructions fit. **This may pass** if row-and-column relationships are essential. Sideways scrolling for the whole page would not be excused. [5]

Common mistake

“Reflow means no scrolling.” One-direction scrolling is expected; ordinary content should not require repeated sideways and downward movement. [5]

Authoritative sources · W3C

[\[4\] Resize Text](#) / [\[5\] Reflow](#) / [\[6\] Text Spacing](#)

Audio and Video

What you need to know

- 1. Captions convey audio in sync.** Include speech, needed speaker identification, and meaningful sounds. Check and correct automatic captions. [7]
- 2. Transcripts support independent reading.** Basic transcripts include speech and relevant audio; descriptive transcripts add meaningful visuals. They support searching, self-paced reading, and assistive technology. [8]
- 3. Description conveys unseen information.** Explain meaningful actions, charts, and on-screen text missing from the soundtrack. [9]
- 4. Match the media type.** At A, prerecorded audio-only needs a text alternative; silent video needs an equivalent text alternative or audio track (1.2.1). Recorded video with audio needs captions (1.2.2); live synchronized media needs captions at AA (1.2.4). Check stated exceptions. [10]
- 5. Level changes the description requirement.** For recorded synchronized video, A allows description or a full media alternative (1.2.3). AA requires audio description for meaningful visuals absent from the soundtrack (1.2.5). A transcript does not replace required captions or AA description. [8-10]

How to think about it

Live or recorded? Audio, video, or both? At the target level, what would someone miss without hearing or seeing? Check each alternative's accuracy and completeness.

Example · identify the missing information

A tutorial says “choose this” while highlighting an option. Captions repeat that ambiguity. **Name the option in narration or description** and update captions if narration changes. A transcript alone is insufficient at AA. [9, 10]

Common mistake

“Captions cover everything.” They convey audio, not an unexplained diagram's meaning. [7, 9]

Authoritative sources · W3C

[\[7\] Captions](#) / [\[8\] Transcripts](#) / [\[9\] Description](#) / [\[10\] Requirements](#)

Three things you should remember

1. Conformance to the rules needs a version, level, scope, and human non-automated evaluation.
2. Enlargement may change the layout, but you must preserve information and function.
3. Captions convey audio, descriptions convey visuals, transcripts support reading.

AI use: OpenAI Codex synthesized W3C sources and helped with citation.